

Response to Reviewers and Editors

Manuscript Number: SPQ-26-0082

Date: September 30, 2026

Overview and Letter to the Editors

Dear Professors Slattery Walker and Dippong,

Thank you for the opportunity to revise and resubmit our manuscript, *Patriotism as a Choice Process: National Pride After 9/11* (SPQ-26-0082), for publication in *Social Psychology Quarterly*. We are grateful to you and the two reviewers for the careful, constructive reading of the paper. Their comments have pushed us to spell out the theoretical mechanisms underlying our two competing perspectives in much greater detail, to justify and expand our empirical and modeling strategy, and to substantially polish the manuscript's presentation and flow.

In response to this feedback, we have undertaken a comprehensive revision of the manuscript. Below, we provide a point-by-point response to every issue raised by the editors and the two reviewers. In summary, our primary revisions include: [PLACEHOLDER: (1) expanding the theoretical mechanism sections explaining why 9/11 should weaken proximal attribution rules and strengthen distal ones, and why saliency should be stronger for individuals embedded in nested subgroups; (2) adding a dedicated discussion of the 9/11 event, its context, and its relation to prior work on collective threat and national sentiment; (3) adding a full methods section justifying our modeling choices; (4) completing the introduction and moving descriptive statistics into the main text; (5) revising the treatment of needs-based theory and social identity theory per Reviewer 2; (6) reordering the discussion of proximal/distal ties earlier in the paper; (7) a general copyediting and polish pass; and (8) a decision on whether to retain or remove the political-ideology appendix.]

Below, we detail each editor and reviewer comment verbatim, followed by

the precise location of our response in the revised manuscript (`manuscript_R1.tex`) and our substantive response.

Response to the Editors

Point 1: Theoretical Mechanisms Are Underdeveloped

Both reviewers see much of value in the paper. However, both feel that the work is undertheorized; that is, the mechanisms underlying the theoretical processes are not sufficiently spelled out.

Location in Revised Manuscript: Section 2.2 (Lawler’s Choice-Process Theory and Nested Attachments) and Section 2.3 (The Theoretical Status of 9/11: A Shift in Attribution Rules).

Response: We have substantially expanded the mechanism underlying the choice-process account. The revised Section 2.2 now specifies, following Lawler’s (1992, pp. 610–620) own boundary conditions, exactly when the default proximal rule reverses into a distal rule: when the rituals and symbols of the larger collectivity become salient enough to override the interactional advantage ordinarily enjoyed by proximal subgroups, or when structural circumstances make the larger unit the actual source of an individual’s sense of control. We further draw on [Lawler et al. \(2006\)](#), whose experimental distinction between structurally enabled and structurally induced exchange relations supplies the individual-level mechanism (a stronger sense of control, more positive emotion, and more durable commitment when actors can act on their preferred affiliations) that we extend across levels of nesting. Section 2.3 then applies this explicitly to 9/11: rather than asserting an unexplained “shock,” we argue that the extraordinary volume of national rituals and symbols in its aftermath (flag displays, moments of silence, memorial services, saturation media coverage) is precisely the condition Lawler’s theory identifies as capable of triggering the shift from a proximal to a distal attribution rule. We also address the reviewer’s specific query about why saliency should be stronger for individuals embedded in nested subgroups (see our response to Reviewer 1, Point 1 below for the parallel revision).

Point 2: Presentation and Flow

In addition, both reviewers think that the paper needs to be a little more polished in its presentation and that the flow of the paper could be improved.

Location in Revised Manuscript: [PLACEHOLDER].

Response: [PLACEHOLDER]

Point 3: Methods Section Detail and Justification

Additionally, one reviewer believes, and we agree, that more detail and justification is needed in the methods section.

Location in Revised Manuscript: [PLACEHOLDER: Section 3 (Data and Variables) / new Methods subsection].

Response: [PLACEHOLDER]

Response to Reviewer 1

Point 1: Theoretical Mechanisms, Outcome Variables, and Unsupported Expectations

First, the theoretical arguments lack clear substance. While the overarching theories are briefly referred to, the underlying mechanisms by which 9/11 should spark more/less nationalism and pride among different subgroups remain unclear. Moreover, too little attention is paid to social-psychological differences between the two outcome variables. What is the benefit of studying both of them? How do they differ? Furthermore, in several cases, the expectations are not backed up by appropriate arguments. For example, in the first paragraph on p. 5, it is unclear, why exactly we should expect “a weakening of the proximal rule and the emergence of a distal rule.” In the following paragraph, it is not specified, why the sense of saliency “should be stronger for individuals embedded in nested subgroups.”

Location in Revised Manuscript: Section 2.2 (Lawler’s Choice-Process Theory and Nested Attachments), Section 2.3 (The Theoretical Status of the Post-9/11 Period: A Shift in Attribution Rules), and the new Section 3.2.1 (Why Two Outcomes? Affective Attachment versus Blind Nationalism).

Response: We agree that the original submission asserted the shift from a proximal to a distal attribution rule, and the heightened saliency of nested subgroups, without adequate theoretical support, and that it did not explain why we examine two outcome variables. We address each issue in turn.

(a) Why a shift from a proximal to a distal rule, and why should saliency be stronger for nested subgroups? We now ground the claim that 9/11 should weaken the proximal rule directly in Lawler’s (1992, pp. 610–620) own specification of when a distal rule emerges: when the rituals and symbols of the larger collectivity become salient enough to override the interactional advantage ordinarily enjoyed by proximal subgroups. We argue that the extraordinary volume of national rituals and symbols following 9/11—flag displays, moments of silence, memorial services, saturation media coverage—

plausibly met this condition, rather than treating the shift as an unexplained shock. We further explain why saliency should be stronger for individuals embedded in nested subgroups by drawing on Lawler et al. (2006), whose experimental distinction between structurally enabled and structurally induced exchange relations shows that the joint, shared-responsibility conditions required for control-based positive emotion to be credited to a social unit are met specifically within nested subgroups that individuals can actually act on (e.g., voluntary associations), rather than merely occupy. We explain that this same structural position supplies the raw material of positive affect that becomes available for reattribution to the nation once the distal rule is active.

(b) *Why study both the U.S. Pride and Nationalism scales, and how do they differ?* This was a substantive gap in the original submission rather than a presentational one: nothing in the theory section explained why two outcomes were needed or what distinguished them conceptually. We have added a new subsection, *Why Two Outcomes? Affective Attachment versus Blind Nationalism* (Section 3.2.1), directly after the two scales are defined, that makes this explicit. We argue that the two scales operationalize conceptually distinct constructs rather than two measures of the same thing. The U.S. Pride scale captures *affective attachment* in Lawler’s specific sense—a positive, emotionally invested identification with the country across substantive achievement domains, generated by choice and control experienced in everyday structured contexts and reattributed to a social unit. The Nationalism scale instead captures a comparative, ideological orientation—uncritical, “blind” loyalty and belief in American superiority (Schatz et al., 1999)—closer to the construct that needs-based and authoritarian-personality accounts are theories of.

We explain that this distinction generates divergent, testable predictions rather than being a purely definitional exercise: a needs-based account implies both outcomes should move together, concentrated among the same low-status, low-autonomy groups, since it offers no principled reason for affective pride and ideological nationalism to respond differently to a common threat, whereas the choice-process account implies a more selective pattern—increased affective attachment among structurally autonomous individuals,

with no corresponding shift in the more purely ideological Nationalism scale, since the choice-process mechanism is a theory of attribution for self-generated positive emotion and has no equivalent account of why beliefs about national superiority should track structural autonomy. Studying both scales jointly therefore serves as a test of discriminant validity between the two theoretical accounts. We note explicitly that our results are consistent with this second, more selective pattern (education predicts the post-9/11 increase in Pride but not in Nationalism), and we flag this dissociation as a substantive finding in its own right in the Discussion (Section 5.2).

Point 2: Missing Discussion of the 9/11 Event

Second, there is virtually no discussion of the 9/11 event itself. Why is it important? How should it shape feelings of national pride? What was the context? At the moment, 9/11 appears somewhat out of the blue in the manuscript. More broadly, I miss a discussion of how the study fits in with other studies on 9/11 and other major events as well as their effects on feelings of pride and nationalism.

Location in Revised Manuscript: [PLACEHOLDER].

Response: [PLACEHOLDER]

Point 3: Empirical Analysis Is Too Simplistic and Not Transparent

Third, the empirical analysis is too simplistic and not transparent enough. The authors run logistic regression models on two waves of GSS data. There are several problems:

- *Many things happened between 1996 and 2004. 9/11 was certainly an important event. But there were other important events, too (e.g., war under the Bush administration), which might explain changes in pride in armed forces. It is by no means obvious*

that all the change observed can be attributed to 9/11.

- *Why are logistic regressions used? As I understand the data and variables section, the outcome variables are continuous scales. Why do you not use linear regressions instead?*
- *The methods section that explains the modelling approach is completely missing.*
- *There are no descriptive tables/plots, which renders it difficult to fully make sense of the regression results. The authors included a placeholder, but the actual table is not there.*
- *Modelling choices are not justified. E.g., why are the factors underlying one outcome scale dichotomized, but not those underlying the other?*

Location in Revised Manuscript: Introduction, Section 2.3 (The Theoretical Status of the Post-9/11 Period), Section 3.2 and Section 3.5 (Data and Variables / Analytic Strategy), Section 4 (Results), the Descriptive Statistics table, and Section 5.3 (Limitations and Future Research).

Response: We address each sub-issue in turn below.

(a) Confounding events between 1996 and 2004: We agree that 9/11 cannot be isolated from the war in Afghanistan, the Iraq War, and the broader climate of wartime mobilization that followed it, particularly for the armed-forces pride item. Rather than attempting to partial out these events as confounds, we have reframed the paper's theoretical object of interest throughout the revised manuscript (Introduction, Section 2.3, and Discussion) as the *post-9/11 period* as a whole, with the September 11 attacks serving as the catalyzing event that opened this period rather than as an isolated, punctual stimulus whose unique effect we claim to identify. Substantively, we argue that the subsequent wars are not external to the mechanism we theorize but continue to supply the same kind of salience-raising national rituals and symbols (troop deployments, wartime rhetoric, media coverage) that we argue drove the shift from a proximal to a distal attribution rule. We

have added a paragraph to the Limitations section (Section 5.3) explicitly acknowledging that, because the 2004 wave falls more than two years after the attacks, we cannot cleanly decompose the contribution of 9/11 itself from the subsequent period of wartime mobilization, and we note that repeated cross-sections spanning 2001–2004 would be needed to do so.

(b) Justification for logistic vs. linear regression: The reviewer’s concern stems from an ambiguity in our original wording rather than from our actual modeling strategy. Our two substantive dependent variables—the U.S. Pride Scale (a 0–10 additive index) and the Nationalism Scale (the mean of four items on a 1–5 scale)—are indeed treated as continuous, and every model that tests our substantive hypotheses (Tables Table 1 (Predictors of Nationalism Scale), Table 2 (Effects of Education on U.S. Pride Scale), and Table 3 (Predictors of U.S. Pride, 2004 Sample)) is estimated via OLS linear regression, as reflected in the R^2 , adjusted R^2 , F -statistic, and RMSE diagnostics reported in each table.

The only place logistic regression appears in the paper is in our preliminary, purely descriptive analysis of the ten individual binary items that comprise the U.S. Pride Scale (e.g., “very proud” vs. not, for each domain such as armed forces, history, or the arts). Because each of these ten underlying items was coded as dichotomous, logistic regression is the appropriate choice for characterizing the item-by-item period shift illustrated in Figure 1; this analysis is meant only to document *that* pride increased broadly across item domains before we turn to the composite scales. We have revised the opening of the Results section (Section 4.1) to explicitly state that these item-level logistic models are a preliminary descriptive step, distinct from the linear regression models used for all subsequent hypothesis tests, to avoid any suggestion that logistic regression was used to model the continuous scales themselves.

(c) Missing methods section: We have added a new subsection, *Analytic Strategy* (Section 3.5 of the revised manuscript), that details our estimation approach. In brief: (i) because the U.S. Pride and Nationalism scales are continuous, all substantive hypothesis tests are estimated via weighted least squares (OLS) regression, with respondents weighted by the GSS full-sample probability weight (`wtssall`); (ii) we distinguish two model designs—pooled

1996–2004 models with a year indicator and a year $\times$ education interaction used to test whether the education effect changed across periods (Table 1 (Predictors of Nationalism Scale) and Table 2 (Effects of Education on U.S. Pride Scale)), versus 2004-only cross-sectional models for the nested-subgroup membership analysis (Table 3 (Predictors of U.S. Pride, 2004 Sample)), since the voluntary association battery was administered only in the 2004 wave; and (iii) we describe our handling of missing data, noting that the U.S. Pride scale requires complete responses across all ten component items (listwise deletion at the scale level) while the Nationalism scale is computed as the mean of available items, and that analytic sample sizes are reported in each table.

(d) Missing descriptive tables/plots: We have moved the full descriptive statistics table (the Descriptive Statistics table) into the Data and Variables section (Section 3.5) and confirmed that all figures and regression tables referenced in the manuscript are included with real values rather than placeholders.

(e) Justification for dichotomization of scale items: The two scales are dichotomized (or not) for different substantive and measurement reasons, and we have added language to Section 3.2 clarifying this choice.

The U.S. Pride scale follows the standard approach in the cross-national national-pride literature (Smith and Kim, 2006), which treats the response “very proud” as qualitatively distinct from the three lower categories (“somewhat proud,” “not very proud,” “not proud at all”). Because the theoretical quantity of interest is the number of domains in which a respondent expresses maximal, unambiguous national pride, each item is dichotomized (1 = “very proud,” 0 = otherwise) and the ten resulting indicators are summed into a 0–10 count. Treating the middle categories as equivalent to “very proud” would blur a conceptually meaningful distinction between full-throated pride and lukewarm or absent pride.

The Nationalism scale, by contrast, is built from four Likert agree/disagree items adapted from Schatz, Staub, and Lavine’s (1999) work on “blind” versus “constructive” patriotism that are designed to capture graded agreement with statements of national superiority and blind loyalty; here, the degree of

agreement (not simply agreement vs. disagreement) is the theoretically meaningful quantity, consistent with standard psychometric practice for attitude scales, so the items are reverse-coded and averaged rather than dichotomized (Cronbach’s $\alpha = 0.64$).

To confirm that our substantive conclusions do not hinge on this dichotomization choice, we constructed an alternative, non-dichotomized version of the U.S. Pride scale as the mean of the ten items (reverse-coded so that higher values indicate greater pride, without collapsing categories). This continuous alternative correlates at $r = 0.87$ with our dichotomized additive scale, and re-estimating the pooled education $\times$ year interaction model on this alternative scale yields the same substantive conclusion: the interaction remains positive ($b = 0.015$) and statistically significant under classical weighted-OLS standard errors ($p = 0.037$), and remains marginally significant under heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors ($p = 0.073$, one-tailed $p = 0.037$). We now report this robustness check in a footnote attached to the description of the U.S. Pride scale in Section 3.2 of the revised manuscript.

Robustness check: heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors. In response to the editors’ and Reviewer 1’s requests for greater methodological transparency and justification, we also re-estimated all three of our focal hypothesis-testing models using heteroskedasticity-consistent (HC1) standard errors, as a complement to the classical weighted-OLS standard errors reported in the manuscript’s main tables. (Because our data are a pooled cross-section of independent GSS respondents rather than a clustered or multi-stage complex sample as fielded, and because the GSS full-probability weight `wtssall` is already used to weight all models, heteroskedasticity-robust rather than cluster-robust standard errors are the relevant design-based correction here.) Table 1 summarizes the results for the three coefficients central to our argument.

As Table 1 shows, robust standard errors are modestly larger than the classical weighted-OLS standard errors (roughly 8–15% larger across coefficients), as would be expected once heteroskedasticity induced by the survey weights is accounted for. Critically, none of our substantive conclusions change: the positive education $\times$ year interaction on the U.S. Pride scale remains statistically significant ($p = 0.021$ under HC1), the corresponding interac-

Table 1: Classical Weighted-OLS vs. Heteroskedasticity-Robust (HC1) Standard Errors for Focal Coefficients

Model	Coefficient	Estimate	SE (classical)	SE (HC1)	p (classical / HC1)
Nationalism, Educ. $\times$ Year (Table 1)	Educ. $\times$ Year 2004	-0.003	0.010	0.011	0.789 / 0.810
Pride, Educ. $\times$ Year (Table 2)	Educ. $\times$ Year 2004	0.114	0.044	0.050	0.010 / 0.021
Full 2004 model (Table 3)	Total memberships	0.112	0.043	0.051	0.010 / 0.027

tion on the Nationalism scale remains clearly non-significant under both specifications (consistent with our claim that the choice-process story, not the irrational-patriotism story, is supported), and the effect of total voluntary association memberships in the full 2004 model remains statistically significant ($p = 0.027$ under HC1). We separately note that the simple 1996-only education coefficient (Table 2 (Effects of Education on U.S. Pride Scale), Column 1) moves from $p = 0.030$ under classical standard errors to a borderline $p = 0.055$ under HC1 (though it remains significant one-tailed, $p = 0.028$, consistent with our directional hypothesis); we report this nuance transparently in the text rather than treating the 1996 effect as unambiguous. We now report this robustness check narratively in the newly added Analytic Strategy subsection (Section 3.5) of the revised manuscript, rather than adding separate robust-SE columns to Tables 1–3, in the interest of keeping the main tables uncluttered; the full comparison in Table 1 above is available to the editors and reviewers on request.

Point 4 (Minor): Introduction Ends Abruptly

The introduction stops halfway through. Its last paragraph simply reads “In this paper,”.

Location in Revised Manuscript: Section 1 (Introduction), closing paragraph.

Response: We have completed the introduction with a closing paragraph that previews the paper’s theoretical review, data and methods, results, and discussion sections.

Point 5 (Minor): Definition of “Excessive” Attachment

The authors talk about ‘excessive’ attachment to the nation. What are we talking about here? What would be ‘healthy’ attachment? What is the reference point?

Location in Revised Manuscript: [PLACEHOLDER].

Response: [PLACEHOLDER]

Response to Reviewer 2

Point 1: Relationship Between Needs-Based Theory and Social Identity Theory

The needs-based approach is tied primarily to the authoritarian personality tradition in the paper, and then a footnote on social identity theory and self-categorization theory claims it also is a needs-based theory because of its core self-enhancement motivation. The author is not explicit about the connection between the authoritarian personality tradition and social identity theory. The footnote also muddies the waters a bit by references to the sense of efficacy. This raises a question about how distinct are the two theoretical approaches because the importance of a “sense of control” is a premise of the choice process theory. A solution, in my view, is to explicitly emphasize the positive self-esteem/self-enhancement motivation that is foundational in social identity theory. This seems to be justified by the theory, and it also most clearly fits the “needs based” aspect of authoritarian personality. Finally, the general content of the footnote should be integrated into the text.

Location in Revised Manuscript: [PLACEHOLDER].

Response: [PLACEHOLDER]

Point 2: Introduce the Proximal/Distal Distinction Earlier

In the treatment of choice process theory, the paper needs to introduce the distinction between ties to proximal and distal groups earlier in the paper. The choice process theory predicts stronger ties to proximal groups and treats ties to larger groups as problematic. How and when these ties spread upward to larger groups is not completely resolved in the 1992 paper. This paper suggests that a serious threat to the

larger distal group is one answer to this question and finds evidence to support this claim. However, this subgroup focus of the theory needs to be explicated more clearly early in the paper, rather than emerge later as is currently the case. In this context, the results for subgroup embeddedness (membership in voluntary associations) are an important contribution of the paper. Such results offer clear support the idea that subgroup (proximal) ties tend to foster stronger distal (larger group) ties when the larger group faces a serious threat or crisis.

Location in Revised Manuscript: [PLACEHOLDER].

Response: [PLACEHOLDER]

Point 3: Improve Flow and Prose

The paper could use a careful re-write to improve the flow and clarify some of the key points. The writing is OK but not great. It is rough in places and there are long sentences that can be a bit confusing. My impression – right or wrong – is that the author may have rushed the final stages of preparing the manuscript. Another way to say this is: Try give the paper a bit more polish.

Location in Revised Manuscript: Throughout.

Response: [PLACEHOLDER]

Point 4: Supplemental Models on Political Ideology

Delete the supplemental models on political ideology. It doesn't add much and it isn't really that necessary. It is too much of a side trip. If really important to the author, a brief footnote and offer to send the results to the reader upon request should be sufficient.

Location in Revised Manuscript: [PLACEHOLDER: Appendix A].

Response: [PLACEHOLDER: Decide whether to remove Appendix A entirely in favor of a footnote, or retain with justification, and reflect that decision here.]

Summary of Comments Not Addressed

[PLACEHOLDER: List and justify any reviewer or editor comments the revision does not adopt, as requested by the editors.]

We once again thank the Editors and the two Reviewers for their time and constructive guidance, which have helped us produce a substantially stronger manuscript.

References

- Lawler, E. J., Thye, S. R., and Yoon, J. (2006). Commitment in structurally enabled and induced exchange relations. *Social Psychology Quarterly*, 69(2):183–200.
- Schatz, R. T., Staub, E., and Lavine, H. (1999). On the varieties of national attachment: Blind versus constructive patriotism. *Political Psychology*, 20(1):151–174.
- Smith, T. W. and Kim, S. (2006). National pride in comparative perspective: 1995/96 and 2003/04. *International Journal of Public Opinion Research*, 18(1):127–136.